



ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

making inroads into remote geographies. A significantly high level of financial inclusion of the population in remote locations will be a major enabler towards these goals.

As we enter the *Amrit Kaal* towards India@100, we, however, need to look hard at the poverty-struck population, which constitutes about 25.01 per cent of the total, that could slow down the transformative change the country is undergoing. This section of the population, unfortunately, is subject to some of the most intractable problems, including inter-generational cycles of poverty, lack of access to quality education and healthcare, and inadequate participation of women in the economy.

The real transformation of India into a top economic superpower is only possible if we are able to keep

this section of our population at the centre of all solutions and include it in the country's growth journey.

It is high time to invoke Mahatma Gandhi's ideology on Trusteeship, of which I am an ardent follower. The path to *Sabka Vikas* (development for all) is to reaffirm our commitment to *Sabka Saath, Sabka Prayas* (with everyone and with everyone's efforts). So, how do we achieve that?

Hyperlocal collaboration: Because ours is a very vast and diverse nation with unique populations and locale-specific challenges, the nation has to be built by its own people, with solutions that emerge through local collaborators at the grassroots.

Strengthening public systems: For transformation to be propelled

by our government, developing a cadre of leaders inspired to drive this change is of critical importance. Additionally, leveraging and optimising technology will ensure that millions of our fellow citizens can access and benefit from the host of government schemes.

Youth as nation builders: I truly believe in the power of our youth that represent our tomorrow. India has one of the youngest populations globally, and what better way to secure a strong future than by tapping into the vast potential and passion of youth through deep dives and experiential learning programmes designed to let their leadership abilities and compassion emerge.

Proportionate representation of the vulnerable: A large percentage of our underserved population comprises women who do not have adequate agency. Ensuring proportionate representation for women on platforms that matter at the grassroots can go a long way in reversing marginalisation. Additionally, by investing in learning and knowledge, and honing the innate leadership skills of these groups, we can ensure that their voices are heard and also feature at the forefront. This will certainly prove to be a game changer.

I perceive India@100 as a land of same opportunities for all. An India that is a force to reckon with.

We have to shape a formidable India together. Let us pledge today that our collective goal and joint determination will be our driving strength, our big ideas the fuel, and the spirit of *Sewa Bhaav* (the spirit to serve) the wind beneath India's wings on her flight to greater heights. **BT**

The writer is Chairman of the Piramal Group